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KF Introduction to NHG

Chapter 1: *The Search for Glory*¹

This book study is designed to give you an overview of the first eleven chapters of *Neurosis and Human Growth*, written by Dr. Karen Horney. The material is dense and somewhat difficult, so Nancy has created simple reading guides to help you identify the main points. Many KF members continue to attend this course year after year because it is not possible to absorb all the information at once. You may find this limitation frustrating or discouraging. Be kind to yourself and allow the information to gently seep into your mind and gradually expand your understanding. Just focus on a few points. Talk about what you are learning with your *Karis Link*, the person who invited you to the study, and then come back again to absorb some more.

For over two decades, Nancy has been actively applying the principles of *Neurosis and Human Growth* to her own life and to the lives of many others. During that time, she has discovered that the themes described in this book consistently correlate with what the Bible teaches about the condition of mankind and the hope of the gospel of Jesus Christ. With the Bible in one hand and *Neurosis and Human Growth* in the other, Nancy has guided hundreds of people in the process of healing their lives and fulfilling their potential.

Dr. Horney first published her definition and analysis of the neurotic psyche in the 1940s, and her research and conclusions about why we think, feel, and do the things that we do are still very valuable for us today. As you study this material, you may begin to identify neurotic tendencies in other people, and that is a great start. Our goal for this course, however, is to recognize the neurosis in ourselves so that we can begin to change the direction of our own lives. Only you can change the person you are. Karis Fellowships training will guide and support you as you go through that process.

You may not like the term *neurosis*. It is a term used in psychoanalysis to describe the condition of anyone who is motivated by compelling needs and ambitious pride—forces that inevitably present obstacles to personal growth and wellbeing. By contrast, healthy people live spontaneously out of their created design, which leads them to fulfill their potential. In Karis Fellowships, we find it helpful to use the term *misorientation* rather than *neurosis* because when we are neurotic, we are not oriented to God or to His design, nor can we develop the person He created us to be. As neurotics, we have misoriented toward a pseudo-person that we have constructed as a survival tool, and that pseudo-person has inflated into an idol-god full of demands and restrictions. This self-created god rules us with more authority than the real God, and that's why we find it so hard to live lives of peace, increasing potential, and consistent joy that the real God promises us. In this study, we will come face to face with the disturbing fact that we are often serving the wrong god.

The wrong god, or Idol Self, compels us to make unrealistic and even self-destructive choices in a frenzied attempt to satisfy its craving for false glory and achieve a sense of superiority and significance. By enforcing its own carefully constructed system of laws and punishments, it asserts its own values and

¹ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

goals while constantly seeking to suppress the real self, the self that God created. Our idealized self, or Idol Self, has definite and very rigid opinions about how life should be and how things should go. Life is full of difficulties and surprises, so this Idol Self is chronically fearful, anxious, strained, and frustrated. This false self is not interested in the truth about you or others. Its sole aim is to save its idealized life.

Neurosis and Human Growth was written to help psychoanalysts identify the problem of neurosis in patients, but it does not really offer a solution. Karis Fellowships training offers a solution, and recognizing that there is an Idol Self is the first step.

We hope that you will make this study a priority as you begin to uncover the secret forces that are driving your life. We would like to remind you again that regular attendance and completing the NHG reading guides is the necessary prerequisite for joining the Karis Fellowship training groups. KF training is not as arduous or time-consuming as the NHG study. KF members learn to take from the training what works for them today, and they celebrate together their progress toward a real life which promotes increasing peace and potential in every area of life.

KF Facilitator Guide

Intro and Chapter 1: *The Search for Glory*¹

0:00 Weekly/0:00 Weekend Intensive (WI)

Lead Facilitator starts the recording by pressing *9.

“Welcome everyone to chapter 1 of *Neurosis and Human Growth*. We will begin our study by reading Nancy’s introduction to the chapter, which I hope you have downloaded from the website.”

Support Facilitator reads the Introduction.

Lead Facilitator: “Thank you. Let’s go to Presenting. Please remain muted until you are ready to talk. When you give us your name and location, you might also share in one or two sentences what brought you to the book study and what you hope to gain from it. We can start with those living furthest east and move west. I will begin.”

“My name is _____ and I am calling from _____. I came to the book study because _____.”

- Facilitators open the [NHG Spreadsheet](#) to record attendance and homework completion.
- Each facilitator makes a list of the names of students as they present.
- Lead facilitator prepares group divisions while students present.
- Lead facilitator assigns groups and says, “To leave the main group, press *3 and then, when prompted, enter your group number. To return to the main group, press *3*.”
- Each facilitator asks, “Is there anyone who has not filled out their reading guide?”
- Each facilitator assigns the first 10 questions to two students, 5 questions each. Continue to answer the questions in sets of 10, assigning 5 questions per student in rotation.

Questions 26 and 36 are open to the whole group, and there are no correct answers.

0:20/0:15 WI

1. What question becomes our new criterion for what we cultivate or reject in ourselves? (15.2)

Is a particular attitude or drive inductive or obstructive to my human growth?

Let’s gently allow ourselves to grow out of neurosis through training. This is not a time to evaluate yourself but simply to answer the questions on the reading guides.

2. What is a better way of dealing with destructive forces in ourselves? (15.2)

We can actually outgrow destructive forces within ourselves.

Our aim is to liberate the forces of spontaneous growth and maximize our opportunities to grow, which will lead to an ever-increasing awareness and understanding of ourselves.

In the process of outgrowing these destructive forces, we get too big for them. They just don’t fit anymore and become unappetizing. The potential of the real self becomes more appealing.

3. What is our prime moral obligation? (15.3)

To work at ourselves.

Working on ourselves is also our prime moral privilege. The more we desire to keep discovering our potential, the more effort we will put into our own development.

It may sound selfish to work on ourselves, but it isn't selfish to work at developing the person God created us to be. In fact, by doing so, we are giving God a gift.

4. When we lose the neurotic obsession with self, what do we become free to do? (15.3)

We are free to grow ourselves, to love, and to feel concern for other people. We will want to give others opportunity for unhampered growth and will help them find and develop themselves.

As parents, and when we are in any position of authority, it is particularly important that we lose our neurotic obsession with self. Neurotic insecurities, fears, and needs cannot help but interfere with the development of others.

One of the purposes of KF training is to give others a safe place to develop their real self. As KF parents, we especially want to give our children a safe place to grow.

5. What is the real self? (17.1)

The central inner force in each person which is the deep source of their unique growth.

The real self is the unique person that God created each of us to be. The unique alive forces of the real self are:

- Clarity and depth of feelings, thoughts, wishes and interests
- The ability to tap into our own resources
- Special gifts and capacities
- The ability to relate to others with spontaneity

6. What three things are necessary for healthy development? (18.1)

- A. **Atmosphere of warmth** – provides inner security and freedom
- B. **Goodwill of others** – those who help meet needs and offer guidance
- C. **Healthy friction with the wishes and will of others** – opportunities to disagree

7. What is "basic anxiety?" (18.3)

A feeling of being isolated and helpless in a world conceived as potentially hostile.

A profound insecurity and apprehensiveness with no feeling of belonging. We develop a sense that there is something wrong with us (William James in *Varieties of Religious Experience*).

- No sense of "we", a community of mutual support
- We feel it is "I versus them"
- We feel separated from others or on the outside

8. What are the three prevailing attitudes that children might adopt to solve their conflict? (19.3)

- A. **Compliance** (moving towards people – Pullers)
- B. **Aggressiveness** (moving against people – Pouncers)
- C. **Aloofness** (moving away from people – Pushers)

Each type has certain qualities that are positive aspects of their design, but in neurosis we take these qualities to an extreme. As our neurotic trend becomes more pronounced, we become more rigid,

fearful, and compulsive. When we are stuck in a particular neurotic trend, we exclude or abhor the qualities of the other trends and therefore have fewer skills for handling life.

Healthy people learn to use the strengths of each of the three neurotic trends.

9. What do people desperately need? (21.1-2)

They desperately need self-confidence or a substitute for it, and they need to lift themselves above others.

Even above God – His ways, His design, His plans.

0:25/0:20 WI

10. How does alienation from the real self occur? (21.3)

- **The real self is prevented from straight growth**
- **The neurotic needs to evolve artificial and strategic ways to cope with others**
- **The neurotic is forced to override genuine feelings, wishes, and thoughts**
- **Safety becomes paramount for the neurotic, so innermost feelings and thoughts recede in importance – in fact they are silenced and become indistinct**

This division of our inner self weakens us. We no longer know where we stand or who we are. We have no real moral compass. We have learned to depend on external gambits, performance, and strategies for managing life.

The idealized self is more real to us than the real self, which we have lost. We are no longer in a position to know ourselves as a motivating force, so we resort to habitual actions that make us feel safe. The feelings that motivate those actions are more important to us than our real feelings about our life experiences. In trying to save our neurotic lives, we lose ourselves.

11. What does a person alienated from himself desperately need? (21.4)

A feeling of identity, power and significance.

Have compassion for yourself because you have created neurosis to generate the support you thought you needed to get through life.

12. Through what does a person seem to fulfill the need for identity, power, and significance? (22.1)

Through the imagination. We create in our mind an idealized image of ourselves.

We endow ourselves with unlimited powers and exalted faculties.

13. What becomes the perspective from which neurotics look at and measure themselves? (23.2)

The idealized self.

When we become Christians, we are often harder on ourselves because we have an even stricter standard by which we measure ourselves.

14. Once people believe that they have found a solution to their inner conflicts through the idealized self, are they willing to give it up? (24.1)

No, they will cling to it for dear life.

Neurotics really have no other choice than to hang on to their particular solution. Self-idealization has become compulsive, so rather than condemning people, we can have compassion for ourselves and others who are caught in the neurotic trap.

When we engage in the work of recovery, we really are laying down our lives for Christ's sake.

15. In neurosis, what happens to the energies driving toward self-realization? (24.2)

The energies are shifted to the aim of actualizing the idealized self.

We also try to get others to support us in actualizing our idealized self; we recruit them to fulfill our dreams.

When we come to recognize how much energy is shifted to supporting the idealized self, we can get pretty excited about the potential that will result from redirecting that energy toward our true design and mission.

16. Into what more comprehensive drive does self-idealization grow? (24.3)

The search for glory.

This is the ambition to prove, or to make real, the idealized self – to make something imagined actual in our daily life.

In KF, we call this search for glory the “hope of the Glory of Me!”, and we contrast it with the “hope of the glory of God.” (Romans 5:2)

17. What is the most radical drive toward actualizing the idealized self? (24.4)

The need for perfection.

In this context, perfection means to mold the whole personality into this imaginary idealized self, but whatever we do is never enough to feel satisfied for any length of time. We are always striving for more perfection. We cannot appreciate the reality of what we have accomplished because we are obsessed with how we should have done it better.

- Every neurotic has a different idea of what would be perfect
- “Not only do I need to be perfect, but those associated with me have to be perfect, too”

18. How do neurotics try to achieve their goal of remodeling themselves? (25.1)

Through a complicated system of shoulds and taboos.

This complicated system is our own personal law to help us remold ourselves and others.

- We become our own gods with our own set of commandments
- We become the righteous judges of all the earth based on our personal law
- We lack real legal authority, so we might manipulate the Bible to support our law

19. What is the most obvious element of the search for glory? (25.2)

Neurotic ambition.

0:40/0:30 WI

20. Where is the drive toward external success most strongly applied? (25.2)

Where excelling is most feasible for the given individual at a given time.

- The content of ambition may well change several times over a lifetime
- What counts is the experience and feeling of excelling, not the quality of the achievement or who they are in the process

21. The success that neurotics desire roughly belongs in which two categories? (26.1)

Power and prestige – depending on what is desirable or viewed as success for each individual.

Examples of power:

- Making others do what I want (mastery)
- Initiating conflict in order to win (mastery)
- Undermining or lying to others to get my way (self-effacing)
- Declaring sainthood by adopting a victim role (self-effacing)
- Use of vagueness and lack of communication to frustrate others (resigned)
- Refusal to follow through or stonewalling (resigned)

Examples of prestige:

- Building the biggest house (mastery)
- Belonging to the right groups (mastery)
- Claiming friendships or relationships with attractive or powerful people (self-effacing)
- Attracting admiration by service and self-sacrifice (self-effacing)
- Being lucky, getting results without effort (resigned)
- Boasting about possible accomplishments (resigned)

Comparison and competition: “I need my diamond to be bigger than other people’s diamonds.” Our problem as neurotics is that we are compelled to think, feel, and choose these unhealthy behaviors.

22. What is the last and most destructive element in the search for glory? (26.4)

The drive toward a vindictive triumph.

- Putting others to shame or defeating them through one’s own success
- Celebrating the mistakes or weaknesses of others to feel pride in our own perfection
- We want to rise to prominence so that we can inflict suffering on offenders
- Trying to frustrate, outwit, and defeat others in personal relationships

Vindictive triumph is often relegated to fantasy.

Most people are either unaware of this vindictive drive or only recognize it in fleeting moments.

23. What are the two general characteristics common to all neurotic trends? (29.3)

A. **Compulsive nature**

We cannot help behaving as neurotics. As neurotics, we often have an utter disregard for our own best interests. We are indiscriminate, insatiable, and react severely to frustration.

B. **Imaginary character**

Neurotics are unrealistic and ignore the evidence about themselves and about life. Their imagination is unproductively placed in the service of neurotic needs. An extreme example would be daydreaming.

Recognizing the compulsive nature of neurosis helps us feel compassion for ourselves and others and inspires us to work on ourselves rather than trying to use willpower to avoid unhealthy behavior.

24. The need for indiscriminate supremacy makes us indifferent to what? (30.2)

To the truth, whether concerning ourselves, others, or facts.

We only acknowledge the evidence that supports our imagined idealized self and how we think life should be. This indifference to truth blinds us to realities that could actually help and inform us.

- We shape and select what we call truth according to our neurotic needs
- We gather evidence, even if it is spurious, to support our imagined self and how we think life should be

25. What are two other qualities of the compulsive drives? (30.3–31.1)

A. **Insatiability.**

There is never enough control, love, or freedom to satisfy us.

B. **Intense reactions to frustration**

The intensity of our reactions indicates how strong a grip neurosis has on us.

26. How do you react when you are resisted, obstructed, or blocked?

Open this question to the group.

27. What does a healthy imagination enable us to do? (32.2)

It enables us to feel empathy and to have wishes, hopes, fears, beliefs, and plans. It can bring us closer to the truth about ourselves and make our experience richer.

- We are able to imagine what the glory of God might look like in a situation
- A healthy imagination gives us vision for the options that real possibilities present, whereas in neurosis we tend to think that only one outcome is acceptable

28. In neurosis, what lends the imagination its tenacity and power? (32.4)

The impact of our neurotic needs.

When we are neurotic, the normal checks and balances on our imagination are not functioning.

29. What work of the imagination is more injurious than daydreaming? (33.2)

The subtle and comprehensive distortions of reality, which we are not aware of fabricating.

To actualize the idealized self, we must incessantly invest a huge amount of energy in falsifying reality. The media of our culture supports these distortions.

- Our bright ideas make us a great novelist
- We imagine that given the right circumstances we could be a successful business leader

0:55/0:40 WI

30. What is the most striking characteristic of the search for glory? (34.3)

The imagination goes into the fantastic and into the realm of unlimited possibilities.

The flight of the neurotic's imagination is not shackled by realities, and we are convinced that all things are possible for us. We might have certain limiting characteristics and yet continue to believe that we can override all limitations and achieve our idealized dreams.

Examples:

- A man who needs eye surgery in order to see believes that if he could just go to Bethlehem, God would heal him
- “I do not have to budget my finances or plan for my future, because I am a special case and will be able to magically sidestep the usual limitations that age or poverty imposes”
- “I can become a gymnast even though I am six foot two”

31. With whom is the neurotic competing? (35.1)

God.

You have said in your heart, “I will ascend into heaven; I will exalt my throne above the stars of God; I will sit also upon the mount of the congregation, on the utmost heights of Mount Zaphon. I will ascend above the heights of the clouds; I will make myself like the most High” (Isaiah 14:13–14).

“Nothing is impossible with God” (Luke 1:37), but the neurotic’s version is “Nothing is impossible for me!”

Examples:

- I am so superior and wonderful that I can control the choices of others, or I should be able to
- I can relieve all suffering, or I should be able to
- I can change the world, build a big business, or make everyone love me – at least I should be able to

32. What two things does a person need for well-functioning? (35.2)

- A vision of possibilities, a perspective of infinitude**
- The realization of limitations, of necessities, and of the concrete**

The dictates of our neurotic needs conflict with well-functioning. Our well-functioning is related to being humble and willing to recognize our real limitations. In well-functioning, we choose humility over the pride of fulfilling our search for glory. We accept our limitations as gifts that guide us to make healthy choices.

If we approach life with humility, God will exalt us at the right time and offer possibilities that are beyond all that we can ask or imagine according to the power that works within us (1 Peter 5:6, Ephesians 3:20).

33. What are all neurotics loath to recognize? (36.1)

They are loath to recognize limitations to what they expect of themselves and believe it possible to attain.

As neurotics, we are loath to recognize or even blind to the limitations that would prevent us from attaining what we expect of ourselves and what we believe we can do.

34. When it comes to our particular illusions about ourselves, we are averse to what? (36.3)

We are averse to checking with evidence when it comes to particular illusions about ourselves.

If we were to check the evidence of our lives, our illusions about ourselves would collapse. Checking one thing would require checking the whole thing – and that’s just too scary.

35. What is the basic difference between healthy strivings and neurotic drives? (37.4)

The basic difference lies in the forces prompting them.

- Healthy strivings – driven by God and truth and lead to the actualization of real potentialities
- Unhealthy strivings – driven by the need to fulfill illusions and lead to building our house on the sand (Matthew 7:26–27)

36. What motivates you to invest in your own growth or development?

Open this question to the group. There are no right answers.

Examples:

- Hope in the resurrection
- Hope that we can change our lives
- Desire to be conformed to the image of Jesus
- The inner work of the Holy Spirit
- The hope that the glory of God will be seen in our lives and declared in the world
- Worship – obeying our Lord

37. From what does the search for glory spring? (38.2)

The need to actualize the idealized self.

Our neurotic search for glory does not declare God's glory. We actually resist the work required to manifest His character and love through our lives.

Healthy people declare the glory of God through the real self (John 15:8, Matthew 5:16, Isaiah 61:3). Neurotics are not interested in the real self because it doesn't support their ideas of what their glory should look like.

38. In what process do neurotics become uninterested as they seek to attain glory? (38.2)

They become uninterested in the process of learning, doing, or gaining step by step – indeed, they tend to scorn it.

We scorn the process of gradually gaining skills and a lifestyle. We want instant gratification. We don't want to have to make an effort. We consider ourselves to be so special that we should be exempt from needing to go through the laborious process of step by step growth.

39. In the search for glory, the emphasis shifts from "being" to what? (38.2)

Appearing.

We want to appear ideal to others, but also to ourselves. We can think of "being" as what we actually do and achieve rather than what we imagine we do and achieve. As neurotics, we want to be a fully formed idealized self and not the simple human creature that we are.

1:10/0:50 WI

40. Compare healthy strivings and neurotic drives. (38.3–39.1)

Neurotic Drives

- Compulsion – driven by idealized self
- Deny limitations
- Focus on the glorious end
- Seeming or appearing
- Motivated by fantasy

Healthy Strivings

- Spontaneity – strivings integrated with who I actually am
- Recognize and honor limitations
- Commit to the process of growth – a feeling of evolution
- Being – I am the same person in all situations
- Motivated by truth

The difference between neurotic drives and healthy strivings is like the difference between a dead Christmas tree and a living fruit tree. One is shinier and decorated with what we think is pretty, but it is exhausting itself and dying. The natural tree may not be so exciting, but it is alive, connected, subject to limitations, and consistently produces fruit in its season (Psalm 1:3, Jeremiah 17:8).

41. What two powerful desires tempt us to sell our soul? (39.2)

- A. **Longing for the infinite** – the offer of unlimited powers
- B. **Wishing for an easy way out** – hoping that our neurotic tendencies will make life easy

42. In an effort to save our lives through neurotic structures and self-idealization, what do we in fact lose? (39.2) See Matthew 16:24-26.

Our soul.

1:15 All Weekly subgroups return to main group by pressing *3*.

0:55 WI students take a five-minute break. Break-out room (subgroup) facilitator returns to the main meeting (*3*) to report attendance and homework, then goes back to the subgroup and waits for the next facilitator to arrive before signing off. Facilitator, do not turn off the recording.

Lead Facilitator: “It is not possible to absorb all this material the first time around. Your ability to understand this material is not about intelligence or whether you are making enough effort. Your goal is simply to gain some familiarity with the material. Do what you can and give yourself credit for what you are able to do. The next two chapters are the longest in the course, so you might want to get started early on your reading guides.”

If time permits, here are some discussion questions:

- How is everyone feeling?
- Do you have any questions or comments?
- How might your approach to this material indicate your neurotic trend?
 - Do you feel like you need to understand everything in this book?
 - Do you feel overwhelmed, helpless, or hopeless?
 - Do you feel bored and irritated by the limitations of the study or the group?
- What strategies did you find helpful when preparing your reading guides? Did you work on it all at once, find a certain place to work in, or perhaps work with someone else?

1:30 (approx.) **Lead Facilitator:** Dismiss the group and stop the recording. (*9 then 1)

All facilitators, please stay after the meeting to confirm student attendance and homework completion on the [NHG Attendance Spreadsheet](#) located on the website under NHG Facilitator Info tab.

Lead Facilitator: “Are there any comments or questions?”

¹ This reading guide refers to the 1991 edition of *Neurosis and Human Growth: The Struggle Toward Self-Realization* by Karen Horney, published by W.W. Norton and Company Inc. New York.